

Flashcards — Plain English + the wording that scores

Built around your 3 exam questions. Each card has two parts:

- **The idea in plain English** — so you actually understand it (say this in your own words first; it's the real test).
- **↔ Say:** the exact phrasing that earns marks — the proper term and/or the thinker — dropped on top of your plain answer to show you've engaged with the readings.

You don't need every fancy word. But a clear argument **plus** one correctly-used term or name is what lifts a good answer to a top one. Cover the right column, give the plain idea, then check the "↔ Say" line.

Your 3 questions: **Q1** = weeks 9–11 (nuclear, drones, robots) · **Q2** = weeks 1–8 (foundations) · **Q3** = synthesis (link a foundation to a modern case).

START HERE — the master key (powers all 3)

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The two basic ways to judge ANY action?	By results (more good than harm?) or by rules (some acts are just wrong, whatever the result). ↔ Say: "This is fundamentally a clash between a consequentialist view — judge by outcomes — and a deontological (or absolutist) view — some acts are wrong in themselves."
The war example that shows the clash.	You could end a war by deliberately bombing a city of innocents. Results view: maybe okay, fewer deaths. Rules view: never. ↔ Say: "The consequentialist weighs the outcome; the deontologist holds that deliberately killing the innocent violates an absolute constraint, whatever the gain."
Weakness of judging only by results?	It can justify monstrous things (harm one to please many) — there's no "you must never." ↔ Say: "Pure consequentialism leaves no room for inviolable rights — in principle it could license atrocity if the sums came out right."
Weakness of judging only by rules?	You might let a disaster happen just to keep your own hands clean. ↔ Say: "Strict absolutism risks privileging your own moral purity over the people you could have saved."
Meaning a harm vs just knowing it'll happen?	Meaning it = your aim or method; knowing = an unwanted side-effect. Meaning it is far worse. ↔ Say: "That's the intention/foresight distinction — and it's the engine of the Doctrine of Double Effect ."

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The two separate questions about ANY war?	(1) Was it right to start it? (2) Are they fighting it fairly? Judge each alone — one can be yes, the other no. ↪ Say: "We keep jus ad bellum — the justice of going to war — independent from jus in bello — justice in how it's fought."

Q2 PREP — Foundations (weeks 1–8)

Example questions: *"Is the realist right that morality doesn't apply to war?" · "Strongest form of pacifism and the best objection?" · "What makes someone a legitimate target?"*

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
Argument that morality doesn't apply to war?	War is about survival; fight nicely while the enemy doesn't and you lose, so anything goes. ↪ Say: "That's realism — Morgenthau and Bacevich — morality has no purchase in an anarchic international order."
What's wrong with it?	If true you couldn't call any atrocity wrong, only say you dislike it — but we clearly can. ↪ Say: "Separate descriptive realism (states often do act self-interestedly) from prescriptive realism (they <i>ought</i> to) — and as Orend argues, saying a state 'should' do anything already smuggles morality back in."
Argument that war is always wrong?	Killing is always wrong, and/or war's costs always outweigh the good. ↪ Say: "That's pacifism — Tolstoy — and I'd distinguish absolute pacifism from contingent pacifism (war just never pays)."
Best objection to pacifism?	Treating all killing as equal blurs the line between killing a soldier and murdering a baby. ↪ Say: " Anscombe's point in <i>War and Murder</i> — pacifism is <i>pernicious</i> because it erases the distinction between the combatant and the innocent, which can actually license atrocity."
The middle view the unit uses?	War is sometimes okay, but only if it passes strict tests in why it's started and how it's fought. ↪ Say: " Just war theory — it blends deontological <i>limits</i> (never target the innocent) with consequentialist <i>checks</i> (proportionality)."
Main accepted reason to start a war?	Self-defence — a country defends itself like a person fighting off an attacker. ↪ Say: " Walzer's legalist paradigm — aggression against sovereignty justifies defensive war, by analogy with individual self-defence."

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The clever challenge to that?	A person defends a life; a country often defends institutions or borders, not lives — the analogy strains. ↪ Say: "Rodin's reductivist challenge — national self-defence can't be reduced to individual self-defence, so the standard justification for war is shakier than it looks."
Other checks before starting a war?	Genuine reason? more good than harm? last resort? real chance of success? ↪ Say: "The rest of the jus ad bellum criteria — just cause, legitimate authority, right intention, proportionality, last resort, reasonable prospect of success."
Invading to save foreigners — case FOR?	A country's right to be left alone shouldn't shield mass murder. ↪ Say: "The Responsibility to Protect (R2P) — Annan's 'sovereignty as responsibility': sovereignty lapses when a state slaughters its own people."
Case AGAINST?	"We're just helping" is easily an excuse, and interventions often backfire. ↪ Say: "Coady's critique, and Krasner's line that sovereignty is 'organised hypocrisy' — with Libya as the cautionary case."
The most important rule once fighting starts?	Only deliberately attack fighters — never deliberately attack civilians. ↪ Say: "The principle of distinction (discrimination) — non-combatant immunity is the heart of <i>jus in bello</i>."
Why are civilians off-limits (3 candidate reasons)?	They're innocent, OR harmless, OR not responsible for the threat (the last is strongest). ↪ Say: "The three grounds for immunity — innocence, harmlessness, or non-responsibility — and the Primoratz-Sparrow debate turns on which one does the work."
What really makes someone a fair target?	Whether they're responsible for an unfair threat, not just the uniform. ↪ Say: "McMahan's liability account — targetability tracks moral responsibility for an unjust threat, which rejects Walzer's moral equality of combatants."
Can civilians ever die "okay-ly"?	Yes, if it's an unwanted side-effect and proportionate; deliberate killing never. ↪ Say: "The Doctrine of Double Effect — civilian deaths may be permissible if <i>foreseen but not intended</i>, and proportionate."
The catch with "I didn't mean to"?	It can be a cop-out — must be genuinely unintended and proportionate. ↪ Say: "The standard objection to Double Effect — 'foreseen not intended' can be a self-serving redescription."

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
What is terrorism, plainly?	Deliberately attacking innocent people to frighten or pressure a wider group. ↪ Say: " Primoratz's definition — deliberate violence against non-combatants to terrorise and coerce."
Why is terrorism wrong?	It targets innocents on purpose. ↪ Say: "It's a direct violation of non-combatant immunity / distinction ."
Is terrorism always worse than war?	Not obviously — war kills innocents too. ↪ Say: " Held's challenge — judge terrorism by the <i>same</i> standard as war; on a consistent standard it isn't automatically worse."
Can a government be a terrorist?	Yes. ↪ Say: "Terrorism isn't only non-state — there's state terrorism too."
What does "an evil weapon" mean?	Wrong by its very nature, not just for the damage — poison gas, torture. ↪ Say: " Mala in se — evil in itself — a charge only a deontologist can really make; Nagel frames it as absolutism vs utilitarianism in <i>War and Massacre</i> ."

Q1 PREP — modern hard cases (weeks 9–11) ★

Example questions: "Are nuclear weapons *mala in se*?" · "Is targeted killing warfare or extrajudicial execution?" · "Does it matter morally whether a human or a machine kills you?"

Nuclear weapons

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
Why are nukes such a hard case?	Can't tell soldiers from civilians, can't be contained, wipe out whole cities. ↪ Say: "They breach distinction and proportionality at once, and are arguably mala in se — they stress every <i>jus in bello</i> principle simultaneously."
Are nukes "evil in themselves"?	Strong yes — you can't use a big one without massacring innocents. ↪ Say: "Strategic nuclear weapons are arguably <i>mala in se</i> — they cannot <i>in principle</i> satisfy distinction or proportionality, so they're intrinsically unusable within just war theory."
The "threaten vs do" puzzle?	Peace by threat only works if you'd really do it — but doing it is mass murder. ↪ Say: "The deterrence paradox — can it be ethical to <i>threaten</i> (a sincere conditional intention) what it would be unethical to actually <i>do</i> ?"

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
Why is that the rules-vs-results clash?	Results: the threat kept peace. Rules: intending to murder millions is wrong. ↪ Say: "It turns entirely on intention vs act — the consequentialist defends the outcome, the deontologist condemns the standing intention."
A surprising doubt?	Nukes may not actually keep peace; the bomb may not have ended WWII. ↪ Say: " Ward Wilson's 'Gordian Knot' — deterrence may not work, and the Soviet invasion (not Hiroshima) may have caused Japan's surrender — so even the consequentialist defence is shaky."

Drones / targeted killing

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
Basic worry about a drone killing?	Off the battlefield — is it war (killing an enemy is allowed) or execution without trial? ↪ Say: " Targeted killing blurs armed conflict with law enforcement — warfare or extrajudicial execution ?"
The worst version?	Killing by behaviour pattern without knowing who they are. ↪ Say: " Signature strikes — targeting by 'pattern of life', not confirmed identity."
The "zero risk" worry?	No danger to you — it looks like hunting, and makes war too easy. ↪ Say: "The problem of asymmetric / riskless war — Sparrow questions whether killing without mutual risk still counts as war."
Case FOR drones?	Precise, fewer civilian deaths than the alternatives, protects your troops. ↪ Say: " Byman's 'Why Drones Work' — precision and force-protection."
Case AGAINST drones?	Civilian deaths radicalise populations and create more enemies. ↪ Say: " Boyle's blowback argument — drone campaigns are strategically counter-productive."

Killer robots (machines that choose who to kill)

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
Killer robot vs drone?	A robot picks and kills its own targets; a drone still has a human firing. ↪ Say: " Autonomous weapon systems (AWS) select and engage targets <i>without meaningful human control</i> ."

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The "no one's responsible" argument?	If it kills wrongly, no one's fairly to blame — not programmer, commander, or machine. ↪ Say: " Sparrow's responsibility gap — <i>jus in bello</i> requires someone be justly answerable for a wrongful killing, and with a truly autonomous weapon no one qualifies, so its use is illegitimate."
The "disrespect" argument?	Being killed by a machine that "decided" treats your life as not mattering. ↪ Say: " Sparrow's 'Robots and Respect' — being killed by a machine fails to respect your moral status as a person; no human agent weighs the gravity of your death."
Strongest argument FOR?	Machines don't panic, rage, or seek revenge, so might kill fewer civilians. ↪ Say: " Arkin's 'The Case for Ethical Autonomy' — an ' ethical governor ' could obey the laws of war more reliably than a frightened soldier (cf. My Lai); if AWS kill fewer civilians, refusing them is the worse choice."
How does Sparrow answer Arkin?	Even fewer deaths leaves no one accountable and no respect. ↪ Say: "Better outcomes don't fill the accountability gap or restore dignity — that's the deontological reply to Arkin's consequentialism."
Why does this topic matter most?	It's the examiner's own field. ↪ Tip: name Sparrow's two arguments (responsibility gap; robots & respect) and Arkin as the counter — that alone shows you've read the W11 texts.

Q3 PREP — synthesis (link a foundation to a modern case)

Example questions: "Does Double Effect also excuse drone collateral damage?" · "Can a machine satisfy distinction and proportionality?" · "Is nuclear deterrence defensible on the same grounds a realist defends war?"

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The one link behind most synthesis questions?	"Rules vs results" in a new outfit each time. ↪ Say: "The consequentialism/deontology clash recurs throughout — the deterrence paradox and the Arkin–Sparrow debate are structurally the same argument."
"Only attack fighters" applied to nukes?	A nuke can't aim at fighters only — it breaks the rule by its nature. ↪ Say: "Apply distinction to W9 — nuclear weapons are inherently indiscriminate, which is the route to calling them <i>mala in se</i> ."

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The "side-effect" rule applied to drones?	Are drone deaths a real accident, or are signature strikes too reckless? ↪ Say: "Apply Double Effect to W10 — are civilian deaths a proportionate foreseen side-effect, or effectively <i>intended</i> through recklessness about identity?"
Who's a fair target — applied to drones?	A fair target is whoever's responsible for the threat, not who fits a pattern. ↪ Say: " McMahan's liability vs signature strikes — killing by pattern-of-life severs targetability from established responsibility."
Does "no risk" link fighting back to starting?	Riskless war makes starting a war too cheap. ↪ Say: "Asymmetry (W10/11) feeds back into <i>jus ad bellum</i> — it erodes last resort and lowers the threshold of war."
Deterrence defended like a "survival" argument?	A survival-first view defends it; the rules view says survival can't justify a plan to murder millions. ↪ Say: "A realist (W3) might defend deterrence on <i>raison d'état</i> ; the deontologist replies that survival can't license a standing conditional intention to commit mass murder."

■ The exam habit (use on all 3 answers)

Question	Understand it + ↔ the wording that scores
The shape of a good answer?	Opinion → reason → best objection → reply → example. ↪ Say it aloud: "My view is... because... The strongest objection would be... but I'd still hold that... For instance..."
What the marker most wants?	A clear position + a reason; there's no "right" answer. ↪ Tip: the rubric explicitly rewards taking an intellectual position and supporting it with reasoned argument — never fence-sit.
Rescue move if stuck?	Ask: start-or-fight? results-or-rules? ↪ Say: "Is this a <i>jus ad bellum</i> or a <i>jus in bello</i> question — and does it turn on consequences or on constraints?"

■ Who said what — quick map (revise these names)

Name	The one thing to attach to them
Sparrow (examiner)	Killer robots: the responsibility gap + ' Robots and Respect '; also sceptical of riskless/asymmetric war.
Arkin	Pro killer robots — the ' ethical governor ' could be more humane than soldiers.
Walzer	The legalist paradigm (self-defence) + moral equality of combatants .

Name	The one thing to attach to them
McMahan	Liability — responsibility, not the uniform, makes you a target (rejects Walzer).
Rodin	The reductivist challenge — national ≠ individual self-defence.
Primoratz	Defines terrorism (deliberate violence on the innocent) + responsibility-based immunity.
Held	Judge terrorism by the same standard as war.
Nagel	Absolutism vs utilitarianism (<i>War and Massacre</i>) — the master clash, + Double Effect.
Anscombe	Attacks pacifism as pernicious (<i>War and Murder</i>); defends just war + Double Effect.
Ward Wilson	Doubts nuclear deterrence works; the Soviet invasion (not the bomb) may have ended WWII.
Byman (pro) / Boyle (anti)	Drones: precision/force-protection vs strategic blowback .
Annan (R2P) / Coady (critique)	Humanitarian war: 'sovereignty as responsibility' vs easily abused.
Morgenthau / Bacevich; Orend	Realism vs the just-war rebuttal of it. · Tolstoy — pacifism.